

Teaching Ayah at Home

Pre-K guide, age 4 · reading, writing, and math in under an hour a day
12-week plan following the *ABC See, Hear, Do* letter groups

1. Overview and golden rules
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Teaching Ayah at Home — Pre-K Guide (Age 4)

A practical, play-based plan for teaching a 4-year-old who already knows the alphabet and can count to 10 how to **blend letters and read, write, and do early math**, in **no more than 1 hour a day**, split into short bursts so she doesn't get bored.

What's in this guide

File	What it's for
01-resources-and-recommendations.md	Honest reviews of The Good and the Beautiful, Math with Confidence, Handwriting Without Tears, Logic of English, 100 Easy Lessons, Bob Books, free apps, and which ones to actually buy
02-how-to-teach.md	How to teach letter sounds, blending, handwriting, and math to a 4-year-old, plus the daily rhythm that keeps it under an hour
03-three-month-plan.md	Week-by-week plan for 12 weeks: what to teach each week in reading, writing, and math, and the play activity that goes with it
04-activity-bank.md	60+ short games and hands-on activities organized by skill, so you can swap one in whenever she's bored
05-progress-tracker.md	Simple checklists to tick off as she masters each skill, plus a "what if she's stuck" section
printables/weekly-plans.pdf	Print and hang: one page per week (12 weeks + a blank week) with the letters, words, activities, and a Mon-Fri tick grid
printables/checklists.pdf	Print and hang: letter-sounds chart, "Words I Can Read", "Books I Can Read", "Ayah Can Write", "Ayah's Math", and a monthly sticker chart

The short version

1. **Buy three things** (about \$55 total): *Preschool Math at Home* (Kate Snow), *Handwriting Without Tears: Get Set for School* workbook, and *Bob Books Set 1*. Get a set of **magnetic letters** and a **cookie sheet** too.
2. **For phonics**, use *ABC See, Hear, Do* (Level 1, capitals): letters in groups of 4–5 with a picture and hand motion each, and real CVC words right after each group. The plan in this repo follows that grouping (A B C T M first). Level 2 (lowercase) comes next.
3. **Install Khan Academy Kids** (free, no ads). It's the best "screen time that's actually learning" for this age.
4. **Daily rhythm:** four 10–15 minute blocks with movement in between. Reading, writing, math, then play/read-aloud. Stop each block *before* she's done, not after.
5. **Follow the 12-week plan.** Weeks 1–6 = one letter group a week, blending words from day 4 of week 1. Weeks 6–12 = Bob Books, sentences, heart words, then lowercase.

Golden rules for a 4-year-old

- **Sounds, not names.** She knows "bee, see, dee". Reading needs /b/ /k/ /d/. Every letter gets its sound, picture, and hand motion from the book.
- **Short beats long.** 10 focused minutes beats 30 distracted ones. If she's wiggling, it's over.

- **Play is the lesson, not the reward.** Every skill in this plan has a game version. Use the game version first.
- **Hands before pencil.** Playdough, tweezers, chalk and finger-tracing come before worksheets. Pencil grip and letter formation come from strong hands.
- **Read to her every day.** 15-20 minutes of you reading picture books is the single most powerful thing in this whole plan. It counts as part of the hour.
- **Never test, only play.** If she gets it wrong, just say the right answer cheerfully and move on. No drilling.
- **Take days off.** 4-5 days a week is plenty. Progress at this age comes in bursts, not straight lines.

Resources and Recommendations

Everything below is judged against three things: **a 4-year-old who gets bored easily, learns best through play**, and **a parent with one hour a day**. Prices are approximate US prices as of 2026; check current pricing before buying.

Bottom line first

Skill	Buy this	Cost	Why
Math	<i>Preschool Math at Home</i> by Kate Snow	~\$20	Made exactly for age 3-5. Five-minute games, no workbook, uses things you own. Reviewers consistently say kids think it's play.
Handwriting / pre-writing	<i>Handwriting Without Tears: Get Set for School</i> (Pre-K workbook)	~\$15-20	"Crayon only", multisensory, teaches strokes then capitals in a smart order. Built for active 4-year-olds.
First books to read	<i>Bob Books Set 1: Beginning Readers</i>	~\$15	12 tiny books that use only the sounds she'll learn in Month 2. Finishing a whole book is a huge confidence win.
Phonics spine	<i>ABC See, Hear, Do</i> Level 1 (Stefanie Hohl)	~\$15-20	Letters in groups of 4-5 with a picture + hand motion, then CVC words from just those letters. The plan in this repo follows it.
Optional extra spine	<i>The Good and the Beautiful Kindergarten Prep</i> or <i>Logic of English Foundations A</i>	Free PDF / ~\$100	Only if you want more lesson scripting. See comparison below.
Free app	Khan Academy Kids	Free	No ads, no purchases, covers reading and math, genuinely well designed.
Tools	Magnetic letters (lowercase!), cookie sheet, playdough, chalk, tweezers/tongs, dice, pom-poms, index cards	~\$20-30	Used in almost every activity in this guide.

Budget path (~\$70): Preschool Math at Home + HWT Get Set for School + Bob Books Set 1 + magnetic letters + TGTB Kindergarten Prep free PDF + Khan Kids.

"I want it all open-and-go" path (~\$170): the same, but Logic of English Foundations A instead of the TGTB PDF.

Phonics and blending

Ayah already knows letter names, so the job is: **letter names → letter sounds → hearing sounds blend (orally) → blending printed 3-letter words → reading little books**. Any program you choose should do those steps in that order. All of these do.

ABC See, Hear, Do — Level 1 (top pick, and what this plan follows)

- **What it is:** A ~\$15-20 picture book (26 lessons, one per letter) that teaches each capital letter's sound with an animal picture and a hand motion. Letters come **in groups of 4-5, not A to Z**, and after every group the child sounds out CVC words using only those letters (the first group gets *cat*

and *mat*). By the end she has read 55 words, and a review page adds 48 more. Level 2 does the same with lowercase; later levels add blends, digraphs, and sight words. There's also a matching activity guide, coloring book, and writing-practice book per level.

- **Pros:** Cheap. Multisensory (see, hear, do) so it suits a wiggly 4-year-old. Blending starts in the first week, which keeps her motivated. Simple enough that you don't need a teacher's manual.
- **Cons:** It's a book, not a full program: no games, no writing, no math. That's what this repo adds around it. Do one letter a day and the group's words all week; don't rush through the book in a fortnight.
- **Verdict:** Use it as the phonics spine. Buy Level 2 (lowercase) around Week 10.

The Good and the Beautiful (TGTB) — Preschool and Kindergarten Prep

- **What it is:** A gentle, open-and-go homeschool curriculum. The *Preschool* course (ages 3–5) covers letter names and sounds, early math, and fine motor skills. The *Kindergarten Prep* course book (30 lessons) is the bridge to kindergarten: letter sounds, blending, and beginning handwriting. Cathy Duffy's review notes Kindergarten Prep takes "a few months rather than a year", which matches this 3-month plan almost exactly.
- **Pros:** Very affordable (the course PDFs are free to download from their site; printed books are around \$30–40). Beautiful, calm design. Short lessons. Parents describe it as "not just cute, it's solid, structured, and it works".
- **Cons you should know:**
 - It is a **faith-based (Christian) curriculum**. Stories, songs, and examples include religious content. Some families love that; if it doesn't fit your family, choose Logic of English instead.
 - Kindergarten Prep asks for more pencil control than many 4-year-olds have (Cathy Duffy's review makes the same point). Skip or shrink the writing parts and do handwriting through HWT instead.
 - The Preschool course will feel too easy on letter *names* for Ayah, since she already knows them. If you go TGTB, start with **Kindergarten Prep** and go slowly, or just use the Preschool course's letter-*sound* pages.
- **Verdict:** Great choice if the faith content is welcome and you want cheap and simple. Use it as the spine and add the games from this repo.

Logic of English — Foundations A

- **What it is:** A secular, research-based (Orton-Gillingham style) program for ages 4–7. Level A teaches letter sounds, phonemic awareness, blending, and handwriting all together, through lots of games and movement.
- **Pros:** Genuinely play-based; reviewers say it's "very motivating" for even 3-year-olds. Teaches *all* the sounds a letter can make from the start (e.g., that "a" says three sounds), which pays off later. Includes handwriting, so you can skip a separate writing program. 90-day money-back guarantee.
- **Cons:** Most expensive option (~\$95–100 for teacher's manual + workbook, plus \$40–60 in manipulatives like phonogram cards and game pieces). Lessons are written for 30–60 minutes; **you must split them across days** to stay under an hour and keep her attention. It is slower-paced than it needs to be for a child who already knows letters.
- **Verdict:** Best all-in-one if you want one purchase that covers reading and writing and you don't want religious content. Do half a lesson a day.

Teach Your Child to Read in 100 Easy Lessons

- **What it is:** A \$15–20 scripted book, 20 minutes a day, based on Direct Instruction. Very strong research track record.
- **Cons:** Dry. Uses a special font with marks that she'll later have to unlearn. The reviews and parent reports agree: it works, but children (especially 3–4-year-olds) often **tire of it once the stories**

get longer. For a child who gets bored easily, this is the risky pick.

- **Verdict:** Only if she likes structure and you like a script. Not my first choice for Ayah.

All About Reading — Pre-reading

- **What it is:** ~\$90 kit with a puppet (Ziggy), letter cards, and activity sheets covering letter names, sounds, and rhyming. Very fun, very gentle.
- **Cons:** It does **not teach blending**; that's Level 1 (another ~\$120). Since Ayah already knows letter names, half of Pre-reading is review. Poor value here.
- **Verdict:** Skip. You'd outgrow it in a month.

Bob Books (Set 1: Beginning Readers)

- Twelve small books, each using only a few letters, starting with "Mat sat." Perfect first readers for Month 2–3 of the plan. Set 2 continues the same way. Around \$15 per set. **Buy Set 1.**

Free reading resources worth using

- **Khan Academy Kids** (app, free, no ads): letter sounds, blending, and math, wrapped in games. Best free option by far. Use it as a 10-minute "screen block" when you need a break, not as the main lesson.
- **Teach Your Monster to Read** (free on a web browser; the app costs a few dollars): a game where a monster learns sounds and blends. Kids love it. Matches Month 1–2 of this plan.
- **Starfall ABCs** (free part of Starfall): letter sounds with animations.
- **Progressive Phonics** (free printable PDFs): little stories where you read most of the words and she reads the highlighted ones. Nice for Month 3.
- **Your library:** ask for "decodable readers" or "phonics readers." Many libraries have Bob Books to borrow.

Math

Preschool Math at Home — Kate Snow (top pick)

- **What it is:** A ~\$20 book of simple, sequenced games for ages 3–5: counting, comparing, subitizing (seeing "three" without counting), shapes, patterns, and the first ideas of adding and taking away. Uses household items only. Each activity is about 5 minutes.
- **Why it fits Ayah:** It's literally "math as playing." Reviewers report their 4-year-olds called each activity a "math game." No worksheets, no writing required, so it doesn't fight with her fine-motor stage. It also matches her level exactly: she counts to 10, and this builds real number *understanding* on top of that.
- **What comes next:** When she turns 5, move to *Kindergarten Math with Confidence* by the same author (~\$40 for instructor guide + workbook). Families report that transition is smooth.

Kindergarten Math with Confidence

- Excellent, hands-on, 15–20 minute lessons with a review warm-up, an activity, then a short workbook page. **Save this for age 5.** Starting it at 4 usually means the workbook pages become a fight.

The Good and the Beautiful Math K

- Fine if you're already all-in on TGTB and want one look and feel. Otherwise Preschool Math at Home is a better fit for this age and for one-hour days.

Free math resources

- **Khan Academy Kids** (again).
 - **Board games** teach more math than worksheets at this age: *Count Your Chickens*, *Hi Ho! Cherry-O*, *Hoot Owl Hoot*, *Candy Land* (colors, turn-taking), and later *Sum Swamp*. Dominoes and dice are gold for subitizing.
 - **YouTube:** *Numberblocks* (BBC) is the best math show for this age. 5-minute episodes. It's how many 4-year-olds learn number bonds without noticing.
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Writing and drawing

Handwriting Without Tears — Get Set for School (Pre-K)

- **What it is:** The preschool level of the most widely used handwriting program in US schools. "Crayon only." Teaches pre-writing strokes, then **capital letters** in a developmental order (starting with the easy straight-line ones: L, F, E, H, T, I), plus numbers. Optional extras: wooden pieces to build letters, the "Mat Man" song, a slate chalkboard for "wet-dry-try."
- **Pros:** Multisensory, songs, building letters with pieces before writing them. One reviewer said it was a great fit for a *very active* 4-year-old because it "held their attention" with lots of ways to practice the same letter. Rated around 4/5 by parents.
- **Cons:** The workbook alone is a little dull if you skip the hands-on parts. You don't need the full kit; the **workbook (~\$15-20) plus homemade wood pieces or playdough** is enough.
- **Verdict:** Buy the workbook. Do the activities in `04-activity-bank.md` before each page.

Drawing

You do **not** need a drawing curriculum at 4. Drawing *is* handwriting prep: every circle, line and zigzag she draws builds the hand for letters. What helps:

- **Free drawing daily** with chunky crayons, markers, and chalk. Big paper, and vertical surfaces (easel, paper taped to a wall, sidewalk chalk) build shoulder and wrist strength.
 - **Art for Kids Hub** (YouTube, free): "how to draw" videos with a dad and his kids. Pick the simplest ones.
 - **Ed Emberley's *Drawing Book of Animals*** (~\$10): shapes-to-animals drawing. She can follow the little steps with you.
 - **Process art:** painting with q-tips, sponge stamping, cutting with kid scissors, sticker collages. All of these are fine-motor practice.
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What to NOT buy yet

- Any **lowercase cursive** or extensive **lowercase** handwriting program. Capitals first at 4.
 - **Sight-word flashcard packs.** She'll read most "sight words" by sounding out anyway. A handful (the, a, I, is, to, and) is enough for now.
 - **Full kindergarten box curricula.** She's 4. Three light subjects and a lot of play is the right dose.
 - **Tablet apps beyond Khan Kids and Teach Your Monster.** Most "learning" apps are candy with a letter on it.
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Sources consulted

- Cathy Duffy Reviews — ABC See, Hear, Do series
- Rainbow Resource — ABC See, Hear, Do Level 1

- Cathy Duffy Reviews — The Good and the Beautiful Kindergarten Prep
- Cathy Duffy Reviews — The Good and the Beautiful Preschool Course
- The Good and the Beautiful — Choose your Littles course
- Jasmine and the Littles — Is TGTB Preschool worth it?
- The Berning Bunch — TGTB Kindergarten Prep review
- Cathy Duffy Reviews — Preschool Math at Home
- Well-Trained Mind — Preschool Math at Home
- Humility and Doxology — Kindergarten Math with Confidence review
- Kate Snow — Kindergarten Math with Confidence
- Learning Reading Hub — Best learn-to-read programs
- The Nova School — Logic of English review
- Homeschooling 4 Him — HWT Preschool review
- Rainbow Resource — Get Set for School
- Leslie Maddox — HWT Pre-K review
- Charlotte Mason Motherhood — HWT review

How to Teach a 4-Year-Old: Reading, Writing, Math

This is the "method" file. Read it once before you start; come back to it when something isn't working.

The one-hour day

Attention span at 4 is roughly **age + 1 to age × 3 minutes**, so 5–12 minutes of real focus per sitting. The hour is therefore **four short blocks**, never one long one. Between blocks: jump, dance, snack, run outside.

Block	Minutes	What	Feels like
1. Sounds & reading	10-15	The reading step for this week (see plan)	A game with letters
2. Move	5	Anything physical. Non-negotiable.	Recess
3. Hands & writing	10	Fine-motor play, then 1 HWT page or a letter	Craft time
4. Math	10	One Preschool Math at Home game or plan activity	A game with snacks/toys
5. Read-aloud	15-20	You read picture books to her. Anytime; bedtime is fine.	Cuddle time

Total: 50–60 minutes, and only ~30 of it is "lessons." You can split it across the day: sounds after breakfast, math before lunch, reading at bedtime.

Rules that keep her engaged - Stop early. End every block while she's still having fun. "One more!" from her is the goal; "I'm done" is a signal you went too long. - **She picks the order** (within reason). Choice is a huge motivator at 4. - **Same time, same spot.** A predictable "learning basket" on the table after breakfast removes the negotiation. - **Praise effort and specifics:** "You slid those sounds together all by yourself!" beats "Good job." - **Bored = switch, not push.** Every skill has 5+ game versions in the activity bank. Change the game, not the goal. - **Skip a day guilt-free.** Sick, grumpy, big outing? Skip. Read at bedtime and call it done.

Reading: from letter names to reading words

Reading has four steps. Steps 1–3 run together from Week 1 (learn a few sounds, blend them into words, repeat with the next group). Most 4-year-olds who know the alphabet get to step 4 in about 2–3 months at this pace, but **some need 6**. Both are normal.

Step 1 — Letter sounds (Weeks 1-6, one group a week)

She knows "bee". She needs /b/.

- **Say sounds cleanly, with no "uh" at the end.** "mmm" not "muh", "sss" not "suh", "t" as a quick puff not "tuh". This matters enormously for blending later: "muh-a-tuh" never turns into "mat", but "mmm-aaa-t" does.
- **Teach short vowels first** (a as in apple, e as in egg, i as in igloo, o as in octopus, u as in umbrella). One sound per letter for now; c = /k/, g = /g/ hard, y = /y/.
- **Teach letters in small groups and blend words right away** (the *ABC See, Hear, Do* approach). Group 1 is **A, B, C, T, M**; with just those she reads *cat, mat, bat, tab, cab, at, am*. One new letter a

day, then words from that group all week. The full group order is in [03-three-month-plan.md](#); if your book's groups differ, follow the book.

- **Capitals first**, like the book's Level 1 (it also matches handwriting, which starts with capitals). Use capital magnetic letters now; add lowercase in Week 11 by matching each small letter to its capital.
- **Attach each sound to the book's picture and hand motion**. Do the motion every time you say the sound; actions lock sounds in memory.
- **2-3 minutes of review daily**: flash the letters she knows, she says the sound. Make it a race, a whisper game, a "trick the puppet" game.

Step 2 — Hearing sounds blend (oral blending, alongside Step 1, no letters)

Before she blends printed letters, she must hear that /k/ /a/ /t/ is *cat*. This is done with **no letters at all**, just voices.

- **Robot talk**: "Please pass the c-u-p." She figures out "cup!" Do it constantly: at meals, in the car, with toys.
- **Start with 2 sounds** ("m-e" = me, "u-p" = up), then 3 ("s-u-n"). Start with **continuous sounds** (m, s, n, f, l, r, v, z) because they can be stretched: "mmmaaannn."
- **Reverse it** (segmenting): "How do we say *dog* like a robot?" "d-o-g!"
- **First-sound games**: "I spy something that starts with /m/." Rhyming: "cat, hat, bat, ___?"

She's ready for step 3 when she can hear "s-u-n" and say "sun" most of the time.

Step 3 — Blending printed words (starts Week 1, after the first letter group)

Now put the letters in front of her.

- **Use 3 magnetic letters on a cookie sheet**. Say the sounds slowly while you slide your finger under them: "sssaaat... sat!" Then she does it.
- **Continuous blending** is the best first method: hold each sound and glide into the next with no stops. "mmmaaap" → "map."
- **Successive blending** if that's hard: blend the first two, then add the third. "sa... sat."
- **Word families**: change one letter at a time. *sat* → *mat* → *map* → *mop* → *top* → *tip*. One letter swap per turn keeps it easy and a little magical.
- **CVC words only** (consonant-vowel-consonant): cat, sun, pig, dog, bed. No "silent e", no "th/sh", no "ee" yet. That's for later.
- **Use only the letters she has so far**. Week 1 words come from A B C T M; each new group adds new words. Short-e (Week 3) is the hardest vowel to hear, so lean on the hand motion.
- **Tiny doses**: 3-6 words a session. Five minutes. Done.

Step 4 — Reading little books and sentences (Weeks 6-12)

- Start **Bob Books Set 1** when she can blend most CVC words with a little help. Book 1 is "Mat sat." She'll read a whole book in the first sitting and be *very* proud.
- **Introduce a few "heart words"** (sight words that don't follow the rules yet): *the*, *a*, *I*, *is*, *to*, *and*. Just tell her: "This one we know by heart: *the*." Two per week max.
- **Point-and-slide**: she puts her finger under each word and slides as she blends.
- **Reread**. Reading the same tiny book 3 days in a row builds speed and confidence. That's not cheating; that's fluency.
- **You still read to her every day**. Her own reading is 5 minutes; your read-aloud is 15-20.

Things that look like problems but aren't

- **Guessing from the picture** → cover the picture, point to the first letter, "what sound?"

- **"kuh-a-tuh... cup?"** → sounds too choppy. Go back to continuous blending and stretchy words (*sun, man, fin*).
 - **Knows all sounds but can't blend** → it's a hearing thing, not a letter thing. Two weeks more of oral blending games (step 2), no letters.
 - **Reads a word, then can't read it 10 seconds later** → totally normal at 4. Decoding is the skill; memory comes with rereading.
 - **Reverses b/d** → normal until 6-7. Teach "b has a belly, d has a diaper" or the "bed" trick with fists. Don't worry.
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Writing: hands first, letters second

At 4, most of "writing" is **building the hand**. The pencil is the last step, not the first.

Readiness checklist (work on these whichever aren't there yet)

- Holds a crayon with fingers, not a fist (a **tripod grip** starts to emerge at 4; don't force it, but use short crayons and golf pencils, which make a fist grip impossible).
- Can draw: vertical line, horizontal line, circle, cross (+), then square, diagonal lines, X, triangle. **This order is developmental**; a triangle usually appears around 5. Capitals need mostly lines and circles, which is why they come first.
- Can cut with kid scissors along a straight line.
- Uses tweezers/tongs to pick up small things.

The teaching order

1. **Pre-strokes** (weeks 1-3): lines, circles, crosses, in sand, on chalkboards, in the air, on big paper.
2. **Capital letters** (weeks 3-12) in the HWT order, because it goes easy → hard: - Frog-jump capitals (start at top left, jump back to top): **L, F, E, H, T, I, U, C, O, Q, G, S, J** - Then: **D, P, B, R, N, M, K, A, V, W, X, Y, Z**
3. **Her name** in capitals (start whenever she has the letters for it; A-Y-A-H is all easy strokes!).
4. **Numbers 1-10** (Month 3, mixed into math).
5. **Lowercase** comes in the *next* three months, not these.

How to teach a letter

Every letter, same four moves, five minutes total: 1. **Build it** with wooden pieces, playdough snakes, or popsicle sticks. 2. **Trace it big** on a chalkboard, in a salt tray, or in the air with a whole arm, while saying the strokes out loud ("big line down, little line across"). 3. **"Wet-Dry-Try"** (HWT's trick): you write it in chalk, she traces it with a wet sponge, then a dry paper towel, then writes it herself in chalk. 4. **One workbook row** in crayon. Then stop.

Vertical surfaces (easel, wall paper, fridge, shower wall with bath crayons) strengthen the wrist and set the hand in the right position. Use them a lot.

What to expect

- Letters will be big, wobbly, and sometimes backwards. Fine.
 - Two or three letters a week is a good pace. Some weeks: none, just playdough. Also fine.
 - Never make her erase and redo. Circle the best one on the row and say why it's the best.
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Math: understanding, not just counting

She counts to 10 by rote, which is great. The next layer is **knowing what numbers mean**. Preschool Math at Home covers all of this in the right order; here's what it's aiming at so you can spot the learning in daily life.

The five big ideas for age 4

1. **One-to-one correspondence:** touching one object per count word. "Count the crackers" with real crackers. Slow her down: "touch and count."
2. **Cardinality:** the last number you say is *how many*. "So how many crackers?" If she recounts, she's not there yet. Keep playing.
3. **Subitizing:** seeing 1, 2, 3 (and later up to 5) without counting. Dice, dominoes, dot cards, fingers. "How many? Don't count, just look!"
4. **Comparing:** more, fewer, same. Two piles of snacks: "Which has more? How do you know?" Line them up to check.
5. **Number sense to 10:** knowing 5 is 4 and 1, or 3 and 2 (number bonds). Fingers are the best tool: "Show me 5. Now hide 2. How many are showing?"

Plus the "shape and pattern" strand: naming circle, square, triangle, rectangle; building AB and ABB patterns with blocks, beads, or stickers.

How to teach a math game

- **Real things, always.** Snacks, blocks, toy animals, pom-poms in a muffin tin. A worksheet with pictures of apples is a poor substitute for apples.
- **You play too.** It's a game, so take turns, sometimes lose, sometimes make a silly mistake for her to catch ("One, two, four!" "Noooo, three!"). Catching your mistakes is a huge learning move.
- **5 minutes.** Then the game "goes back in the basket until tomorrow." Leaving them wanting more is the trick.
- **Narrate math all day:** "You have 2 shoes and I have 2 shoes, that's 4 shoes." "We need 3 more plates." "Which cup is taller?" This "math talk" is proven to matter more than any workbook.

Where she should be by the end of 3 months (typical, not required)

- Counts objects to 10 accurately, rote counts to 20 or so.
- Recognizes numerals 0-10 (and can match them to quantities).
- Subitizes to 4 or 5.
- Compares two groups; knows "more/fewer/same."
- Adds and takes away within 5 with objects or fingers ("2 cars and 1 more car is 3").
- Names basic shapes, copies an AB pattern.
- Writes a few numerals (messy is fine).

The 3-Month Plan (12 Weeks)

Printable version: [printables/weekly-plans.pdf](#) has each week below on one page with a Mon-Fri tick grid, ready to hang up. [printables/checklists.pdf](#) has the hang-up checklists (letter sounds, words, books, writing, math, sticker chart).

How the letters are organized (the ABC See, Hear, Do way): letters come in **groups of 4-5**, and as soon as a group is learned she **blends real words from just those letters**. Week 1 is A, B, C, T, M and she reads *cat, mat, bat, tab, cab* by Friday. No waiting a month for blending. Use the book's page for each letter (picture + hand motion), and use the words printed in the book after each group. The groups below match the book's approach; **if your copy's next group is different, follow the book** and write its letters into the boxes on the printable.

Capitals come first (like the book's Level 1), which also lines up with handwriting. Lowercase is introduced in Week 11 and continues after the 3 months.

Codes: **PMAH** = *Preschool Math at Home* (about one activity a day, in book order). **HWT** = *Handwriting Without Tears: Get Set for School*. **AB #** = activity number in [04-activity-bank.md](#).

Daily structure: sounds & words 10-15 min → move 5 min → hands & writing 10 min → math game 10 min → story time 15-20 min. Weekends off.

Month 1 — A new letter group every week, words right away (Weeks 1-4)

Week	Letters	Words she blends	Writing	Math	Play of the week
1	A B C T M	at, am, cat, mat, bat, tab, cab, tam	Hand play (playdough, tweezers, chalk). Strokes: line down, line across. HWT stroke pages.	Touch-and-count to 5, "so how many?" Dot cards 1-3. PMAH first activities.	Sound treasure hunt (AB #3)
2	S I R P	sit, sip, tip, pit, rip, rat, sat, bit, rib, tap, map, cap, pat, rim, Sam, Tim	Circles and crosses. Capitals L F E . Short crayons for grip.	Count 10 objects with cardinality. Count back from 5.	Robot dinner (AB #6)
3	E N D H	hen, pen, ten, den, net, bed, red, pet, hat, ham, had, hid, him, hit, dip, did, nap, man, can, pan, dad, sad, mad	Capitals H T I . Air writing. Cutting fringe.	Dice grab 1-4 (subitize). More / fewer with two piles.	Letter-sound hopscotch (AB #4)
4	O G F L + check-in	dog, log, fog, hot, hop, top, mop, pot, cot, dot, not, got, fan, fat, fit, fin, fed, leg, lap, lip, lid, big, dig, pig, bag	Capitals U C O . Bath crayons. Start her name.	Numerals 1-5 ↔ dots/fingers. Number hunt. Count to 15.	Sound sorting bins (AB #7)

Each week, same rhythm: Mon-Thu one new letter a day (book page, sound, hand motion, 2-minute review of all learned letters), and every day 3-5 words built with magnets on the cookie sheet (slide the finger, stretch the sounds, "c-a-t... cat!"). Fri = words only, plus a game. Keep the ear games going all week (robot talk, "say *dog* like a robot", first-sound I-Spy).

Week 4 check-in: flash all 17 letters. Anything wobbly goes on the "practice pile" for 2 minutes a day. If blending is hard, do a week of only ear games and stretchy words (*sun, man, fin*) before moving on. Repeating a week is normal.

Month 2 — Finish the alphabet, first books (Weeks 5-8)

Week	Letters / focus	Words	Writing	Math	Play of the week
5	U J W K (all 5 vowels known)	sun, run, fun, bun, nut, cut, cup, up, bug, hug, mug, rug, jug, jam, jet, job, jog, wet, web, wig, win, wag, kit, kid	Capitals Q G S . Rainbow letters.	Number bonds of 3 and 4 on fingers. "One more." Domino match.	Word family flip book (AB #12)
6	V X Y Z Q — all 26 done. Bob Book 1 on Friday.	van, vet, box, fox, six, wax, mix, yes, yet, yak, yum, zip, zap, quit, quiz + the book's review words	Capitals J D P . Name on a fridge card.	Five-frame. Numerals 6–10. Subitize to 5.	Blending ramp (AB #13)
7	Review words + Bob Books 1-3 . Heart words THE, A .	5 mixed words a day from the book's review page; THE CAT SAT	Capitals B R N . Trace CAT under her drawing.	Count to 20. Shapes hunt, stick shapes.	Secret word treasure hunt (AB #15)
8	Bob Books 4-6 . Heart words I, IS . Sentences.	THE CAT IS BIG. I CAN HOP.	Capitals M K A . Numerals 1 2 3.	Hidden pom-poms (bonds of 5). Roll and add.	Sentence strips (AB #17)

Reading routine from Week 6 on: reread yesterday's book first (warm-up, not a test), then 5 words on the cookie sheet, then one new book or page. Two heart words a week at most; just say "this one we know by heart."

Month 3 — Reading for real (Weeks 9-12)

Week	Focus	Words / books	Writing	Math	Play of the week
9	Bob Books 7-9 . Heart words TO, AND . Story cards about her.	AYAH CAN RUN. AYAH IS 4. Progressive Phonics free books.	Capitals V W X . Numerals 4 5. Label drawings.	Taking away within 5. Countdown rocket.	Reading picnic (AB #19)
10	Bob Books 10-12 . She reads a familiar book alone.	Sticky-note words on real objects: BED, CUP, PAN, TUB, BOX	Capitals Y Z (all 26!). Numerals 6 7. Alphabet poster.	Patterns AB / ABB. Order 3 things by length.	Label the house (AB #21)
11	Lowercase begins (same groups: a b c t m). Bob Set 2 optional.	Match capital ↔ lowercase magnets. Reread Week 1-2 words in lowercase.	Review wobbly capitals. Numerals 8 9 10. Write CAT alone.	"3 + 2" shown with pom-poms. Count to 30. Board game daily.	Board-game week (AB #65)
12	Celebration + check-in . No new content.	Reread favorites. "Books I can read" list. Read to a grandparent on video.	A card: I LOVE YOU. AYAH.	She teaches you her favorite games.	Certificate day (AB #40)

What comes after Month 3

- **Reading:** the rest of lowercase in the same groups, then the book's next levels (blends and digraphs: sh, ch, th, ck), Bob Books Set 2-3.
- **Writing:** lowercase letters (HWT *Letters and Numbers for Me*), short words, her own sentences.
- **Math:** at 5, *Kindergarten Math with Confidence*.

If a week goes badly

- **She's resisting:** cut everything to 5 minutes for a week, keep only games and story time. Resistance is usually "too long," not "too hard."
- **A skill isn't sticking:** repeat the week (use the blank page at the end of the printable). Or go back one step: blending trouble → ear games; letter trouble → hand motions and hunts.
- **She's flying:** don't add subjects. More books, more labels, harder games. Depth over speed at 4.

Activity Bank

Short, cheap, play-based activities organized by skill. Numbers are referenced from the weekly plan. Most take 5–10 minutes and use things you already have. **Swap freely.** If she's bored with one, pick another for the same skill.

Supply basket: lowercase magnetic letters, cookie sheet, index cards, playdough, chalk, salt/sand in a tray, tweezers or tongs, pom-poms, dice, dominoes, sticky notes, a muffin tin, stickers, crayons (broken short), kid scissors, a puppet or stuffed animal.

A. Letter sounds (Month 1)

1. **Sound flash race** — flash cards of learned letters; she says the sound. Time it with a silly countdown; try to beat yesterday. 2 minutes.
2. **Trick the puppet** — the puppet says the wrong sound ("t says /m/!"). She corrects it, giggling. Kids learn most from catching mistakes.
3. **Sound treasure hunt** — hide 5 objects starting with today's sound (sock, spoon, sticker, straw, stone for /s/). She hunts, names each, says the sound.
4. **Letter-sound hopscotch** — chalk letters in hopscotch squares. She jumps and says each sound. Add "jump to the letter that says /m/."
5. **Sensory writing** — write the letter in a salt tray, shaving cream, or finger paint while saying the sound. Then "erase" and do it again.
6. **Robot dinner** — one meal where every request is in robot talk: "pass the c-u-p." Builds oral blending without any letters.
7. **Sound sorting bins** — two bins, two letters. She sorts toys by first sound. (Pig, pen, pot → /p/; sock, spoon → /s/.)
8. **I Spy with sounds** — "I spy something that starts with /b/." Then she gives you one.
9. **Sound actions** — each letter gets an action (look up "Jolly Phonics actions" on YouTube). Play "Simon says /s/."
0. **Alphabet bath** — foam letters in the bath; fish out the one that says /t/. Stick it to the wall and say a word.
1. **Rhyme time** — "cat, hat, bat, ___?" Then silly nonsense rhymes: "zat, wat!" Rhyming trains the ear for blending.

B. Blending printed words (Month 2-3)

2. **Word family flip book** — staple 6 index cards on the left of a card that reads *_at*; flip the first letter: *c, h, m, b, s, r*. She reads each flip.
3. **Blending ramp** — three letter cards lined up next to a cardboard ramp. Roll a toy car past them as she blends; roll faster each time until the word "pops out."
4. **Cookie-sheet swap** — magnets: *sat*. "Change one letter to make *mat*." She swaps. Then *map, mop, top, tip*. One swap per turn.
5. **Secret word treasure hunt** — 5 index cards with CVC words that are also hiding places (*bed, mat, cup, tub, box*). Each word she reads leads to the next clue; the last hides a sticker.
6. **Word building with blocks** — write letters on blocks/Duplos; she stacks them to build the word you say ("build *sun*").
7. **Sentence strips** — silly sentences on paper strips: *the pig can hop. the cat is wet*. She reads and acts it out.

8. **Read to Teddy** — she reads each word she built to a stuffed animal, who "claps."
9. **Reading picnic** — blanket, snacks, a pile of Bob Books; every stuffed animal gets read one page.
0. **Whisper-shout reading** — read the same 5 words in a whisper, then a shout, then a squeaky voice. Rereading = fluency.
1. **Label the house** — sticky notes with CVC words on the real objects (*bed, cup, pan, mat, box, tub*). She reads them as she passes all week.
2. **Story cards about her** — write a 2-line story on an index card: *Ayah can run. Ayah is 4*. She reads it and keeps it in her "my books" envelope.
3. **Word swat** — tape 6 words on the wall. Say one; she swats it with a fly swatter and reads it.
4. **Magic reveal** — write CVC words in white crayon; she paints over them with watercolor to reveal, then reads.
5. **Progressive Phonics books** (free printables) — you read the black words, she reads the red ones.

C. Hands and handwriting

6. **Playdough letters** — roll snakes, build today's capital. Then squish and rebuild. Hand strength + letter shape.
7. **Popsicle-stick letters** — big sticks (long line) and half sticks (little line) build L, F, E, H, T, I like HWT's wood pieces. Curves: a bent pipe cleaner.
8. **Wet-Dry-Try** — small chalkboard. You write the letter in chalk; she traces with a wet sponge, then a dry paper towel, then writes it in chalk herself.
9. **Salt tray strokes** — pre-writing strokes (|, —, O, +, X, □) in a tray of salt. Say the stroke: "big line down."
0. **Rainbow letters** — one big letter on paper; she traces it with 5 different crayon colors.
1. **Vertical writing** — paper taped to the wall, easel, or bath crayons on the tub wall. Builds the wrist and shoulder for good grip.
2. **Tweezers transfer** — move pom-poms from a bowl into a muffin tin with tweezers or tongs. Count them as a bonus.
3. **Cutting strips** — kid scissors, cut a paper strip into "fringe," then cut along a straight line, then a zigzag.
4. **Sticker lines** — put dot stickers along a line, then along a circle, then along a letter's path.
5. **Squeeze and squirt** — spray bottle at chalk letters outside; eyedropper into an ice tray; both build finger strength.
6. **Name puzzle** — her name on a card, cut into letters; she rebuilds it, then traces it, then writes it.
7. **Draw-and-label** — she draws a cat; you write "CAT" lightly; she traces it. Labeling drawings makes writing feel purposeful.
8. **Lacing** — cardboard shape with holes and a shoelace.
9. **Air writing** — whole arm, huge letters in the air, eyes closed, saying the strokes. Great for wiggly days.
0. **Certificate day** — she "signs" her name on a homemade certificate at the end of the 12 weeks.

D. Math

Counting and number sense

1. **Touch and count** — line up snacks; she touches each one as she counts. "So how many?" (cardinality). Eat them (subtraction!).
2. **Counting collections** — a jar of buttons/rocks/LEGO. Count how many, then "make it 10."

3. **Count the steps** — stairs, steps to the mailbox, jumps on the trampoline. Rote counting to 20–30 in real life.
4. **Countdown rocket** — 10 fingers, count down to blast-off while crouching then jumping.
5. **Number hunt** — find numerals around the house (clock, remote, book pages, mailbox). "Which number is this?"
6. **Muffin tin numbers** — number cards 1–10 in muffin cups; she puts that many pom-poms in each (tweezers for bonus fine motor).
7. **Hundred chart pointing** — a printed chart; point and count to 20, then 30. Cover a number; "which one is hiding?"

Subitizing (seeing how many without counting)

8. **Dice grab** — roll a die, grab that many blocks. "Don't count, just look!" Works for 1–4, then 5–6.
9. **Dot card flash** — homemade cards with 1–5 dots in different arrangements; flash for 1 second. "How many?"
0. **Domino match** — turn dominoes face up, find two sides with the same number of dots.
1. **Finger flash** — you flash fingers behind your back and show them for one second; she says the number. Then she does it to you.
2. **Five-frame** — draw 5 boxes; put pom-poms in some. "How many? How many empty spaces?" (number bonds of 5).

Comparing, adding, taking away

3. **More or fewer?** — two piles of grapes; "which has more? How do you know? Let's line them up to check."
4. **Hide the pom-poms** — 5 pom-poms; cover some with a cup. "How many are hiding?" Number bonds without any symbols.
5. **One more, one less** — she has 3 crackers. "I'll give you one more. Now how many?" "The dog ate one. Now?"
6. **Snack math** — "You have 2 apple slices and I have 3. How many altogether? Line them up."
7. **Roll and add** — two dice, take that many blocks each roll, count the tower.
8. **Toy story problems** — "3 cars are in the garage. 2 drive away. How many are left?" with real toy cars.

Shapes, patterns, measurement

9. **Shape hunt** — find 3 circles, 3 rectangles in the house. Photograph them.
0. **Popsicle-stick shapes** — build a triangle (3 sticks), a square (4). "How many sides?"
1. **Pattern beads** — string beads red-blue-red-blue; then red-red-blue. She continues your pattern, then makes one for you.
2. **Body patterns** — clap-stomp-clap-stomp; she continues. Then invents one.
3. **Longer or shorter?** — line up spoons, forks, crayons. Order 3 things from shortest to longest.
4. **Kitchen scale / cup measuring** — pour water into cups: "which holds more?" Bath time counts.

Games that teach math without trying

5. **Board games** — *Count Your Chickens* (cooperative, counting and spinner), *Hi Ho! Cherry-O* (counting, taking away), *Hoot Owl Hoot* (colors, cooperative), *Candy Land* (colors, turn-taking). Play one every day of "board game week" (Week 11).
 6. **Numberblocks** — 5-minute episodes on YouTube; watch one, then build that number with blocks.
 7. **Khan Academy Kids** — 10 minutes of the math path when you need a break.
-

"She's bored" emergency list

Pick one, do it for 5 minutes, and call the block done: - Hopscotch (#4), word swat (#23), air writing (#39), countdown rocket (#44), dice grab (#48), body patterns (#62). - Or: skip the lesson, read two picture books together. That is never wasted time.

Progress Tracker

Tick these off as they become *easy and consistent* (not "did it once"). Print this or keep it on your phone. It's fine, and normal, to have unticked boxes at the end of 12 weeks. Repeat the relevant week.

Letter sounds

Say the sound (not the name) quickly, capitals first (printable version: [printables/checklists.pdf](#), page 1):

Group	Letters	Solid?
Week 1	A B C T M	☐
Week 2	S I R P	☐
Week 3	E N D H	☐
Week 4	O G F L	☐
Week 5	U J W K	☐
Week 6	V X Y Z Q	☐
Week 11+	lowercase a-z, matched to capitals	☐

Practice pile (letters that keep slipping): _____

Hearing sounds (oral)

- ☐ Hears "u-p" and says "up" (2 sounds)
- ☐ Hears "s-u-n" and says "sun" (3 sounds, stretchy)
- ☐ Hears "c-a-t" and says "cat" (3 sounds, stop sounds)
- ☐ Says "dog" as "d-o-g" (segmenting)
- ☐ Tells the first sound of a word ("what does *milk* start with?")
- ☐ Gives a rhyme for "cat"

Blending printed words

- ☐ Week 1 words: cat, mat, bat, tab, cab, at, am
- ☐ Week 2 words: sit, sip, rat, sat, bit, rib, map, cap
- ☐ Week 3 words: hen, pen, ten, bed, red, hat, man, dad
- ☐ Week 4 words: dog, log, hot, hop, top, fan, fin, pig
- ☐ Week 5 words: sun, run, bug, hug, jam, jet, wet, kit
- ☐ Week 6 words: van, box, fox, six, yes, zip, quit
- ☐ Reads mixed CVC words (5 in a row, mostly alone)
- ☐ Knows heart words: the, a, I, is, to, and

Reading books

- ☐ Bob Books Set 1: Book 1 "Mat" ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10 ☐ 11 ☐ 12
- ☐ Reads a familiar Bob Book alone (to a stuffed animal)
- ☐ Reads a 2-line story card about herself

Pre-writing and handwriting

Strokes: ☐ vertical line ☐ horizontal line ☐ circle ☐ cross (+) ☐ square ☐ diagonal ☐ X

Grip: ☐ holds crayon with fingers (not fist) most of the time

Capitals (in HWT order): - ☐ L ☐ F ☐ E ☐ H ☐ T ☐ I - ☐ U ☐ C ☐ O ☐ Q ☐ G ☐ S ☐ J - ☐ D ☐ P ☐ B ☐ R
☐ N ☐ M - ☐ K ☐ A ☐ V ☐ W ☐ X ☐ Y ☐ Z

- ☐ Writes her name in capitals
- ☐ Writes a word under a drawing (CAT, DOG)
- ☐ Numerals: ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ 7 ☐ 8 ☐ 9 ☐ 10

Math

- ☐ Counts 10 objects touching each one once
- ☐ Says "so there are ___" (last number = how many)
- ☐ Rote counts to 20 ☐ to 30
- ☐ Subitizes 1-3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5
- ☐ Recognizes numerals 1-5 ☐ 6-10 ☐ 0
- ☐ Matches numeral to a quantity
- ☐ Compares two groups: more / fewer / same
- ☐ "One more" and "one less" with objects
- ☐ Number bonds of 5 (hidden pom-poms)
- ☐ Adds within 5 with objects
- ☐ Takes away within 5 with objects
- ☐ Names circle, square, triangle, rectangle
- ☐ Copies and continues an AB pattern ☐ ABB pattern
- ☐ Orders 3 objects by length

Habits (the ones that matter most)

- ☐ Read-aloud most days
- ☐ Lessons stopped *before* she was done (most days)
- ☐ She asked to do a game again this week
- ☐ Took at least 2 days off this week

If she's stuck

Stuck on	Do this
A few letter sounds won't stick	Put them on the "practice pile." Two minutes daily of the hunt (#3) or hopscotch (#4) with <i>only</i> those letters. Give each one a body action.
Knows sounds but can't blend	Ears, not eyes. Go back to Week 2-4 oral games (#6, #8, #11) for two weeks with no letters. Then try continuous blending with stretchy words: <i>sun, man, fin, mom</i> .
Blends "kuh-a-tuh" and gets lost	Sounds have an "uh" tail. Practice saying t, p, k, d as tiny puffs. Use only stretchy-sound words for a week.
Guesses from pictures	Cover the picture. Finger under the first letter: "what sound?"
Reads the word, forgets it seconds later	Normal at 4. Reread the same book 3 days running. Speed comes with repetition, not correction.

Stuck on	Do this
Hates writing	Drop the workbook for 2 weeks. Only playdough, chalk, salt tray, tweezers, cutting. Come back to it with air writing (#39) and wet-dry-try (#28).
Reverses letters (b/d, S, N)	Normal until 6-7. Show the right way once, cheerfully. Don't drill.
Counts but skips objects	"Touch and count" (#41). Line objects up in a row. Slow it down; move each counted object to a "counted" pile.
Recounts instead of saying "how many"	Cardinality is still forming. Keep asking "so how many?" after every count and answer it for her sometimes. It clicks.
Bored with everything	Cut to 5-minute blocks. Only games and read-alouds for a week. Let her pick the order. Resistance is almost always "too long," not "too hard."